



TOGETHER WE SAIL:
(L to R) R.R. Patil,
Balasaheb, Uddhav
and Deshmukh

Alliances Unlimited

In his desperate attempt to get back onto political centrestage, Uddhav Thackeray leads Shiv Sena to the politics of pragmatism where none is untouchable including Muslim parties

■ By Aditi Pai and Malini Bhupta

When Uddhav Thackeray was growing up, Bal Thackeray may have told his son many stories from the *Panchatantra*, but the one that's likely to have stuck in Uddhav's mind is one of the tortoise and the hare. Even as voluble critics snigger at his slow pace and controlled demeanour, Uddhav is quietly rewriting some of the tenets of the party. He's attempting to inculcate *sanyam* (self-restraint) in place of *josh* (aggression) so that the Shiv Sena finds more acceptance within secular parties like the Congress and NCP. One of his close aides says, "Unlike Balasaheb, Uddhav thinks from the head and does not let personal relationships affect political

decisions." His rivals in BJP call it political opportunism and attribute the changes in Sena to Uddhav's desire to wrest power at any cost.

Problems within the Sena broke out shortly after Uddhav became the executive president of the party in 2003, easing out other prominent leaders like Narayan Rane and cousin Raj Thackeray. It reached crisis proportions when Rane joined the Congress along with seven MLAs in 2005, reducing Sena's strength to 56 MLAs in the Assembly while Congress tally bloated to 73.

The real impact of these developments is being felt by the ruling coalition and the Opposition allies now, as both marriages are on the brink of a divorce. In its bid to keep Rane out of the

chief minister's chair, the Sena is willing to go to any length, including ditching its 20-year-old alliance partner BJP on core issues. Says Nitin Gadkari, Maharashtra BJP president, "The crisis between BJP and Sena is primarily because they chose to support a Congress candidate for the presidential election and have publicly hailed Sharad Pawar as a prime ministerial candidate. On the floor of the Assembly they backed Vilasrao Deshmukh just to prevent Rane from becoming chief minister. This makes it difficult for us to function as a credible Opposition."

The earliest indications of the tensions surfaced when BJP contested the Chimur Assembly seat in the by-elections in 2006 and put pressure on Sena through L.K. Advani not to field its can-